

FASTING & PRAYER

Today we are embarking upon a spiritual adventure together, a twenty-one day fast! I hope you will follow along each day with Susan and I as we share information on fasting and prayer. As we embark upon this journey I want you to bear in mind that our theme for the year is freedom. We are expecting God to bring freedom into every part of our family, career, finances, and ministries. I do not believe we can expect to live overcoming lives and expect freedom apart from the disciplines of fasting and prayer.

Fasting and prayer are Scriptural principles. One hundred sixty times the Bible references the word fasting or some variation of it. The word fast means *"one who has ~~not~~ eaten, one who is empty"* Our word *"breakfast"* simply means to break our time of fasting between the evening ~~and~~ morning meal. Sad to say, but that is about as much fasting as most Christians ever do.

People point to all kinds of excuses for not practicing

the principle of fasting:

- Fasting makes me sick...
- I am not physically strong enough to fast...
- My schedule will not allow for fasting...
- Fasting is the responsibility of church leaders...

None of these excuses are a good reason for neglecting the discipline of fasting.

Prayer is communication between heaven and earth.

The theme of our journey together **“Touching**

Heaven - Changing Earth”, if we actually touch Heaven with our prayers we will no doubt become anointed to change earth!

I want to challenge us to view our time of prayer and fasting like an airplane. An airplane has three components, two wings and a fuselage. I want us to view the two wings as petition and praise, and the fuselage as waiting in His presence to hear from God.

We are really good at the petition part but we often struggle with the praise and waiting. Lets make the first wing praise and the second wing petition. The

reason I want us to put praise first is because the Bible says *“God lives in the praises of His people.”* God honors gratitude. The leper that was made whole was the one who returned to give Him praise. The other nine lepers were just healed of their leprosy. If you are a leper healing is wonderful but being made whole is AWESOSME! Wholesomeness flows out of gratitude. Please do not hesitate to take your petitions to the Lord during this time but preface your petition with praise.

After we have praised and made our petitions known to the Lord let us not fail to reserve a period of waiting quietly in His presence to hear from Him.

My prayer is that before we are finished with this journey together, you will see such benefit in the spiritual disciplines of fasting and prayer that you will be motivated to not only participate but have regular times of fasting and prayer on your own throughout the year. Remember, fasting and prayer is the most fruitful and productive things you can do.

So on your mark? Get ready, Go!

PERIMETERS OF FASTING

Today I want to point out some perimeters for fasting. One should not go on a radical or absolute fast if one has health problems that would be worsened by abstaining from food or water.

If you are on medications, do not discontinue a medication without the supervision of a doctor. Be aware that some medications must be taken after consuming food and a beverage.

Once you have settled the issue of medication with your doctor you should decide what kind of fast you are going to do and for how long. This is probably a personal preference but I do not like to engage in a fast until I know how long it is going to last. There are several reasons for this:

- As soon as you initiate the fast the flesh

and the enemy will be screaming at you, telling you that you have accomplished your goals and that you should begin eating again.

- Knowing how long you are going to fast from the inception will help you prepare yourself mentally for the journey.
- Having a set time of fasting will empower you to remain engaged spiritually throughout the appointed time.
- As you near the end of the fast, knowing the goal will give you faith that you can accomplish it.

Before beginning a fast of more than three days:

- Receive divine direction - Don't copy others; be sure you are led of the Lord as to what type of fast you are to do and how long it should last.
- No caffeine – Discontinue the use of caffeine a few days before the fast.

- Restrict your food intake several days before the fast - Eat fruit as a last meal before the fast.

During the fast:

- Dress warmly - You can expect to feel colder during a fast, especially in your hands and feet.
- Use warm, not hot, water for showers and baths.
- Avoid ice cold beverages.
- Give extra time to prayer and Bible reading.

I challenge you to read your Bible aloud during this time. The Bible say's "***Faith comes by HEARING...***" As you read your Bible and wait in the presence of the Lord to hear from Him, bear in mind He wants to free you and your family from every bondage.

FASTING IN THE OLD TESTAMENT & THE NEW TESTAMENT

In Judaism the Day of Atonement was a time of complete fasting, this meant no food or water for twenty-four hours. This was the only prescribed time of fasting and it was intended to be a day of national repentance. During the Day of Atonement the participants were to refrain from all labor. If one decided not to fast on this particular day the punishment was death.

The Old Testament employs the “afflict” when describing the discipline of fasting. When we read that a person *“afflicted, sanctified or consecrated themselves,”* the Scripture is simply saying that they fasted.

Fasting in the Old Testament:

- Pastor Moses fasted – (Fasted 40 days twice – The result; the ten commandments)
- The Children of Israel fasted – Judges 20, 1

Samuel 7, 1 Samuel 31, 2 Samuel 1

- King David fasted – 2 Samuel 12, Psalms 69, Psalms 109
- King Ahab fasted – 1 Kings 12
- The servants of Saul fasted – 1 Chronicles 10
- The prophet Ezra fasted – Ezra 8&9
- Nehemiah fasted – Nehemiah 1 (He fasted until God sent him to Jerusalem to rebuild the broken city)
- Mordecai fasted – Esther 4 (Fasted for an intercessor)
- Zechariah and the priests fasted – Zechariah 7
- The prophet Daniel fasted – (Fasted 21 days before receiving an answer and visions) Daniel 9&10
- The prophet Joel fasted – Joel 2

History tells us that during the time between the Old Testament and the New Testament fasting became a Jewish characteristic or mark.

Fasting in the New Testament:

- The Pharisees_fasted
- Jesus fasted – Matthew 4, Mark 2, Mark 9
(This time of fasting prepared Him for public ministry)
- Anna_fasted – Luke 2
- Cornelius fasted – Acts 10 (The Lord sent Peter to present the gift of the Holy Spirit to the gentile world)
- The Apostles fasted – Acts 13 (Paul and Barnabas are selected as the first missionaries of the New Testament church)
- Paul_fasted – 2 Corinthians 6, 2 Corinthians 11

Fasting is both an Old Testament and New Testament principle and activity. If fasting is a New Testament principle it is certainly worthy of the consideration of every Christian. It is my prayer that during this time of fasting and prayer God will reveal Himself to you in a new and fresh way. If this occurs, I believe we will experience freedom as never before!

WHY SHOULD WE FAST?

Let me begin by saying that fasting will not persuade God to do anything that He would not ordinarily do. If we are fasting to convince God to do a miracle we are wasting our time. God already desires to give good things to His children. Matthew 7:11 (KJV) ***“If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father who is in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”*** 2 Chronicles 16:9 (NKJV) ***“For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to show Himself strong on behalf of those whose heart is loyal to Him...”***

If fasting does not convince God to do anything He would not ordinarily do; why fast?

- Because the words of Jesus implore us to do so. Matthew 9:14-15 (NLT) ***“One day the disciples of John the Baptist came to***

Jesus and asked him, “Why do we and the Pharisees fast, but your disciples don’t fast?” 15 Jesus responded, “Should the wedding guests mourn while celebrating with the groom? Someday he will be taken from them, and then they will fast.”

- Fasting is the duty of every Christian. Matthew 6:16 (NLT) *“And when you fast, don’t make it obvious, as the hypocrites do, who try to look pale and disheveled so people will admire them for their fasting. I assure you, that is the only reward they will ever get.”*
- Fasting crucifies the flesh. The flesh is the enemy of faith and therefore it is the enemy of God. Galatians 5:16-26 (NLT) *“So I advise you to live according to your new life in the Holy Spirit. Then you won’t be doing what your sinful nature craves. 17 The old sinful nature loves to do evil, which is just opposite from what the Holy Spirit wants. And the Spirit*

gives us desires that are opposite from what the sinful nature desires. These two forces are constantly fighting each other, and your choices are never free from this conflict. 18 But when you are directed by the Holy Spirit, you are no longer subject to the law. 19 When you follow the desires of your sinful nature, your lives will produce these evil results: sexual immorality, impure thoughts, eagerness for lustful pleasure, 20 idolatry, participation in demonic activities, hostility, quarreling, jealousy, outbursts of anger, selfish ambition, divisions, the feeling that everyone is wrong except those in your own little group, 21 envy, drunkenness, wild parties, and other kinds of sin. Let me tell you again, as I have before, that anyone living that sort of life will not inherit the Kingdom of God. 22 But when the Holy Spirit controls our lives, he will produce this kind of fruit in us:

love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, 23 gentleness, and self-control. Here there is no conflict with the law. 24 Those who belong to Christ Jesus have nailed the passions and desires of their sinful nature to his cross and crucified them there. 25 If we are living now by the Holy Spirit, let us follow the Holy Spirit's leading in every part of our lives. 26 Let us not become conceited, or irritate one another, or be jealous of one another."

- Fasting humbles the believer before God. If we fast a few days we find that we are more humble than ever before.
- Fasting teaches the believer dependence upon God as his source.
- Fasting expresses submission to God. Submission to God helps us appreciate the need of self-discipline. (Matthew 6:10 NKJV) **Your kingdom come. Your will be done On earth as it is in heaven."**

- Fasting prepares us to receive revelation from God. (Moses, David, Nehemiah and Daniel)
- Fasting brings victory! To be Christ ~~like~~ is a of victory. Doubt is of the flesh, refusal to crucify the flesh brings defeat. When ~~we~~ ^{we} crucify the flesh we have victory.
- Fasting places the believer in a position of hearing from God. – (Daniel)

I encourage us to continue on this adventure of fasting and prayer, it will place us in a position to hear from God! When we hear from God, he will speak to us about things that have held us captive and I am sure He will reveal His path to freedom!

WHEN SHOULD WE FAST?

The timing of a fast is probably as crucial as the decision to fast. We are not to fast just for the exercise of it, we are to fast in an attempt to crucify the flesh and move closer to God.

There are times when a believer feels a special need to draw closer to the Lord. This is the Spirit moving within our hearts letting us know that we need to do something out of the ordinary to meet God on His turf.

James 4:5-10 (KJV) ***“Do ye think that the scripture saith in vain, The spirit that dwelleth in us lusteth to envy? 6 But he giveth more grace. Wherefore he saith, God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble. 7 Submit yourselves therefore to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you. 8 Draw nigh to God, and he will draw nigh to you. Cleanse your hands, ye sinners; and purify your hearts, ye double minded. 9 Be afflicted, and mourn, and***

weep: let your laughter be turned to mourning, and your joy to heaviness. 10 Humble yourselves in the sight of the Lord, and he shall lift you up.”

The best way to get on God’s turf is to crucify the flesh; the most effective method of crucifying the flesh is through fasting. Galatians 5:16-26 (CEV) **“If you are guided by the Spirit, you won’t obey your selfish desires. 17 The Spirit and your desires are enemies of each other. They are always fighting each other and keeping you from doing what you feel you should. 18 But if you obey the Spirit, the Law of Moses has no control over you. 19 People’s desires make them give in to immoral ways, filthy thoughts, and shameful deeds. 20 They worship idols, practice witchcraft, hate others, and are hard to get along with. People become jealous, angry, and selfish. They not only argue and cause trouble, but they are envious. 21 They get drunk, carry on at wild**

parties, and do other evil things as well. I told you before, and I am telling you again: No one who does these things will share in the blessings of God's kingdom. 22 God's Spirit makes us loving, happy, peaceful, patient, kind, good, faithful, 23 gentle, and self-controlled. There is no law against behaving in any of these ways. 24 And because we belong to Christ Jesus, we have killed our selfish feelings and desires. (I call fasting dying!) 25 God's Spirit has given us life, and so we should follow the Spirit. 26 But don't be conceited or make others jealous by claiming to be better than they are."

We should fast:

- When God lays a fast on our hearts... We should be sensitive to what the Spirit is saying. If we are constantly feeding the flesh and starving the spirit we will not feel the need to fast.
- When our prayer life needs to be strengthened... Fasting will enhance our prayer lives immensely. It

is in this setting we can sense the nearness of His presence. (Over

- When we need to prepare ourselves to receive God's message... This is probably the greatest benefit of fasting. Oftentimes it is difficult to hear from God during the fast because our flesh is screaming for the fleshly pleasure of food. I have learned that hearing from God after the fast is not difficult at all. Luke 4:13 (NKJV) ***“Now when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from Him until an opportune time.”***
- When we become quiet our spirit... Fasting brings a heightened intimacy with God.
- When we are experiencing crisis in our life... I have made it a practice not to make major decisions without a minimum of three days fasting.
- When spiritual leaders call a fast... This is probably the most difficult fast to embark upon because our response seems more of a response to man than to God. Joel 1:14 (NKJV) **“Consecrate a fast, Call a sacred assembly; Gather the elders And all the inhabitants of the**

land Into the house of the LORD your God, And cry out to the LORD.”

Hebrews 13:17 (NKJV) ***“Obey those who rule over you, and be submissive, for they watch out for your souls, as those who must give account. Let them do so with joy and not with grief, for that would be unprofitable for you.”***

Fasting is a very difficult decision to reach but it is probably one of the most important disciplines Christian life. If we hope to live a life of freedom, we cannot afford to overlook the importance of fasting and prayer.

TYPES OF FASTING

Let's take a look at the different types of fasting in the Bible. I don't want you to feel intimidated or overwhelmed by the thought of going without food for days on end.

There are types of fasting that don't involve such a radical commitment. The Bible gives examples of many different kinds of fasting. The terms I will use to describe the different types of fasts are not biblical terms they are terms I have chosen. Let's look at them:

- Radical fast – This is a fast that includes neither food nor water. This is the type of fast that Jesus and Moses went on. This type of fast can be risky to one's health. One should make sure God is telling one to embark upon such an odyssey. I would not recommend this fast for more than a maximum of three days and then only with a Doctor's approval if you are under a doctor's care.

- Absolute fast – This is when we consume no food at all and drink only water. Jonathan did this in 1 Samuel 20:34. When embarking upon an absolute fast one should make sure God is calling one to do so and one should know how long the fast is to last before it begins.
- Partial fast – In this fast one is to refrain from consuming certain foods. Maybe cut out meat, maybe desert. This is a fast that can go on indefinitely. Daniel, Shadrach, Meshach, Abednego fasted in this way; they refused to eat the Kings meat, bread, or deserts. Listen to the results; Daniel 1:15 (NKJV) ***“And at the end of ten days their features appeared better and fatter in flesh than all the young men who ate the portion of the king’s delicacies.”*** Those who have health problems that would restrict them from a radical fast or an absolute fast can often do this type of fast.

- Intimate fast – This type of fast can be entered into by couples who decide to set aside the pleasures of the flesh to seek the Lord for a specific time period. This should only be done with the consent of both marriage partners. 1 Corinthians 7:5
- Media fast – I can find no scripture for this one but many people go on a media fast. In this culture we are inundated with downloading information from every direction imaginable. This type of fast refrains from any type of media exposure for a certain time period. In fact, if the purpose of fasting is to place ourselves in a position of hearing from God, I would suggest that if we are going to engage in any kind of fast, it should also include a media fast.

No matter what kind of fast you have decided to engage in, you should set aside a time to listen quietly for the voice of God. In

hearing from God we will no doubt begin to see things that have had us bound, that we never suspected were a problem before. I challenge us to deal with each restriction as He identifies it. In so doing, we will continue on a path toward complete freedom in Christ.

HOW TO HEAR FROM GOD

If you have been following the daily devotionals during this time of fasting and prayer you will remember me saying that fasting does not convince God to do anything that He is not already willing to do, it places us in a position of being able to hear from God.

In the Old Testament, Daniel fasted and prayed for twenty-one days. Here is an interesting thing, at the end of twenty-one days the Lord spoke to Daniel and said, ***“I heard you the first time you prayed!”*** Seriously? Twenty-one days of fasting and prayer and Daniel discovered that God had heard his prayer the first time? How frustrating would that be? I would suggest, this is true every time! The Bible says ***“The ear of the Lord is attuned to the cry of the righteous.”*** It also says ***“The eyes of the***

Lord are searching the world for someone to whom He might show Himself strong.”

That doesn't sound like God is playing hide-and-seek with us, it sounds like He is attempting to get His answers to us.

The problem that Daniel experienced is the same problem that we all face. God revealed to Daniel that the issue was not getting his prayers heard; the problem was receiving the answer. The Word revealed that ***“The prince of the power of Persia”*** had hindered the answer for twenty-one days! In other words it took Daniel twenty-one day's of fasting and prayer to position himself to receive the answer.

I do not want to come across as sacrilegious here but it appears to me that the prince of the power of Persia was closer to God than Daniel was. If you do not agree with me you will have to explain how the prince was running interference between Daniel and the

answer, if he was not somewhere between God and Daniel. The cares of this world often drown out the voice of God. We have so many voices screaming into our ears that though we are praying and reading our Bibles, everything else seems to be much more vivid than what we are hearing from God.

This is where setting aside time for fasting and prayer comes into play. It is during this time that we push back our plate and choose by an act of our own will to silence all other voices in lieu of hearing from God.

Remember, fasting does not convince God to act in our behalf; it places us in a position of being better able to hear His voice and receive His answers.

I am anxious to see what God say's to us during this journey of fasting and prayer. His words will no doubt be words of

freedom. In fact, the Word said, ***“You shall know the truth and the truth shall make you free.”***

ENDING A FAST

Ending a fast in a proper manner, especially if you have been on a radical or absolute fast is very, very important. This is true from a physical as well as a spiritual perspective and I want to address both.

After the fast:

- Avoid starches for a few days.
- Chew your food well.
- Stop eating as soon as you feel full.
- Don't become physically active too soon.
- Eat healthy food.

Here is a suggested schedule for reintroducing food after a radical or absolute fast:

- DAY 1: Drink liquids every couple of hours in small amounts. Mix water with fruit juices.
- DAY 2: Eat chicken noodle soup or

something similar. Yogurt in small quantities will be fine.

- DAY 3 & 4: Salads, soups without grease and cooked vegetables.

After a few days you can begin to resume a normal diet of food and exercise. The last thing you should begin consuming is fish and meats.

From a spiritual perspective the best time to hear from the Lord is the time following a radical or absolute fast. Be must be careful not to reengage in behaviors that distract us from our quiet time with the Lord; praying, reading His Word, and taking time to listen intently for His voice. If we handle this time appropriately, we will hear from Him as we never have before.

I think most of you will agree that ninety percent of the battle is getting ourselves in a place to hear from God. If we know that we

know that we know that we have heard His voice, following His directives become much easier for us to do.

Through fasting and prayer we have changed our position from being hearing challenged, to being able to hear from God. Let us be very careful about reintroducing disciplines that caused our hearing problems to begin with. Let us walk in the freedom that He is offering today. ***“He that the Son set’s free is free indeed.”***

LISTEN!
CAN YOU HEAR WHAT GOD IS
SAYING?

Now that we are concluding our time of fasting we should be in a better position to hear from the Lord. Surprisingly enough, I struggle during a fast to hear anything from the Lord. It often seems that Heaven is silent as I fast (Die) and pray. I know we call it fasting but it feels an awful lot like dying!

I have heard people tell awesome stories of what God told them during a fast and I am not taking away from that, but my experience has been that God is strangely silent as I grovel with the discipline of fasting. Here is the exciting part! Once I conclude a fast it seems that God is speaking from every direction!

For a number of years I thought myself to be

somewhat of an odd ball in this area, until I read the account of Jesus' testing in the wilderness. John the Baptist, baptized Jesus in the Jordan River, the Holy Spirit descended in the form of a dove, God spoke from Heaven, and John the Baptist declared Jesus to be the Messiah. You would think Jesus would ride the momentum of the moment into a very public ministry and strike while the iron was hot, but look at what really happened. The Bible said ***“He was led by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tested by the devil for forty days.”*** Seriously? Really? Wow! What a turn of events!

If you study the account of Jesus' forty days of fasting you will notice that the Bible does not record that God said one word during this time. Conversely it reveals that during this time Jesus had at least three face-to-face confrontations with Lucifer himself! Each time the enemy attempted to convince Jesus

to lay down His divinity and pick up His humanity. During this ordeal Jesus never once relied on His flesh to overcome the enemy. He took three scriptures from the Old Testament and whipped the devil all over the desert!

Following the forty day fast, the Word declares, “*Afterward, the devil left Him alone for a season.*” Here is what we are being told through the experience of Jesus:

- The forty days of fasting and solitude was spent crucifying the flesh.
- The time in the desert was a wrestling match between hell, earth, and heaven.
- The victory was not won in heaven or hell; it was won in the desert.
- After the testing Jesus was in such alignment with the Father that the devil was afraid to challenge Him.
- It was following this tremendous challenge that miracles, signs, and wonders began to be revealed through

the earthly ministry of Jesus.

What lessons should we take from this experience of Jesus?

- We should not think it a strange thing if we find our time of solitude to be an uphill battle.
- During the battle we cannot rely on the flesh to win the battle, we must rely on His word to win the day.
- We should expect to hear vividly from God following our time of fasting and prayer.
- We should expect to see God act on our behalf going forward.

Listen! Can you hear what God is saying? He is saying, get ready! Get ready! Get ready! Freedom is on its way into our lives and ministries.

PRAYER THAT PRODUCES FREEDOM

Take a look around you; people are grappling with addictions and phobias of all kinds. Sadly, the bondage of believers often mirrors that of the world. This should not be the case in the life of Christians. We are Christ followers and He paid the price for our freedom at Calvary, all we have to do is walk in the freedom He offers.

The bondages that we experience and allow can and will be broken through with the power of prayer. Psalms 34 (NIT) lays out the freedom God affords through prayer. In

this passage we are told that the Lord will do the following things in response to the prayer of the believer:

- Deliver us from fear (Vs.4)
- Save us from our trouble (Vs. 6)
- Guard and deliver us (Vs. 7)
- Be good to those who trust Him (Vs. 8)
- Supply all needs (Vs. 9)
- Hear us when we pray (Vs. 15)
- Redeem us (Vs 22)

Wow! All of the aforementioned things belong to every Christ follower. I hope we will take advantage of what Christ purchased and step into the freedom He

purchased for us.

We are to receive these things through:

- Crying out to Him (Vs. 6, 17)
- Trusting Him (Vs. 8)
- Fearing Him (Vs. 7, 9)
- Refraining from lying (Vs. 13)
- Humbling ourselves (Vs. 18)
- Serving Him (Vs. 18)

If we walk according to His will and Word
we will find ourselves in a place of freedom
that we have never experienced before.

***“You shall know the truth and the truth
shall make you free.”***

God promises great blessings to His people, but many of these blessings require our active participation. In this instance our participation is a consistent prayer life.

Prayer is a requirement of living an overcoming Christian life. If we hope to live free, we must be people of prayer. My prayer for you and for CT is that we will come into a place of freedom this year that we can see Him for who He is, and we can receive from Him all that He has promised.